The Dementia Diagnosis Target

England, March 2017-2026: what ten annual observations can tell us.

The short answer

The linked CSV records 66.3% in March 2026 (95% confidence interval 59.7-71.8), up from 65.6% in March 2025 and the highest annual figure since 2020. It sits just below the 66.7% ambition. NHS England reported in October 2026 that the two-thirds target had been met on its monthly series; the two series should not be spliced.

What is being measured?

The estimated diagnosis rate compares recorded diagnoses among people aged 65 and over with a modelled estimate of people living with dementia. Recording, demographics and prevalence assumptions can affect the rate alongside diagnostic activity. Coverage is not a measure of diagnostic quality, support or patient outcomes.

The source-CSV pattern

The ten March observations peak at 68.7% in 2019. The rate moves from 67.4% in March 2020 to 61.6% in March 2021, a fall of 5.8 percentage points, followed by a rise in every annual observation through March 2026. Timing is consistent with pandemic disruption; the series alone cannot identify its mechanisms or attribute earlier improvement to a policy.

Statistical limits

The existing X-mR output shows all individual values within limits, with the 2020-2021 moving range above its upper limit. Limits estimated from nine observations are provisional, and the March 2026 point is not in the retained charts. The displayed Bootstrap CUSUM run reports one stage at its selected settings, not proof that no important change occurred or that recovery is assured. A whole-series-centred CUSUM returns to zero by construction.

What to investigate locally

Trace referrals, waits, assessment capacity, workforce and access. Pair coverage with diagnostic review, equity, post-diagnostic support, patient and carer experience, workload and crisis-care measures. State the predicted effect of an intervention and its timescale before evaluation.

Source basis: the nine earlier values are the existing site CSV, attributed by the original article to OHID Fingertips; March 2026 was added from the Fingertips dementia profile. This summary supersedes the earlier PDF's conflicting figures and stronger causal claims.
Full article, corrected table and sources:
https://stepchangeanalysis.com/dementia-diagnosis-rate.html